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What Counts as Assessment in the Age of AI?

Why polished work is no longer enough, and why assessment must establish what the student can actually know, explain, and defend.

By Dr Jabreel Asghar · 24 October 2026

Imagine you design an assessment task and assign it to your students. The following day, the entire class submits polished, carefully structured responses that align almost perfectly with the rubric. As their teacher, you know their usual level of performance. The work in front of you is clearly beyond what most of them could independently produce.

What should you do?

Should you mark the submissions against the published rubric and award the grades they appear to deserve? Or should you question their authenticity, flag them as AI-generated, and ask students to resubmit? More importantly, what would be the basis of either decision?

Generative AI has made this question unavoidable.

Higher education has always been concerned with plagiarism, collusion, contract cheating, and other forms of unauthorised assistance. Yet those concerns usually emerged when there was evidence that a student had copied someone else’s work or misrepresented another person’s writing as their own. AI complicates this distinction. An AI-generated response may contain no copied passage and may not infringe any identifiable author’s ownership. It may nevertheless fail to provide valid evidence of the student’s learning.

This is why describing all unauthorised AI use as plagiarism is conceptually inadequate. The central problem is not always theft of words. It is the substitution of performance. The submitted work appears to demonstrate knowledge, judgement, and skill that the student may not possess.

What, then, is happening to assessment in higher education? Has AI changed the meaning of plagiarism, or has it exposed a weakness that was already present in our assessment design?

Perhaps the deeper problem is that many assessments were never designed to establish authorship. They were designed to evaluate finished products while assuming that the student who submitted the work had also produced the thinking behind it. In the pre-AI classroom, that assumption was imperfect but generally manageable. In the age of generative AI, it has become increasingly difficult to defend.

AI has not simply created a new method of cheating. It has revealed the difference between assessing the quality of a product and assessing the learning that the product is supposed to represent.

AI detection appears to offer an obvious solution, but it does not resolve the deeper problem. Detection tools can only estimate whether a text resembles AI-generated writing. A student may use AI extensively and still revise the work carefully, while another may submit entirely human-written work that is incorrectly flagged. The detector produces another probability, not proof of learning.

Even if detection became more accurate, it would still address only the origin of the text. It would not tell us whether the assessment itself provides valid evidence of student competence. The central issue is therefore not simply whether AI was used, but what role it played and what the final product allows us to conclude about the student. This is why assessment cannot depend on detection as its main defence.

Assessment may therefore need to gather different kinds of evidence. The final product will still matter, but it cannot always stand alone. Educators may need to see how students reached their decisions, how they selected evidence, how they responded to feedback, and whether they can explain and defend the work they submitted. The purpose is not to force students to prove that they worked without assistance. It is to establish whether the learning claimed by the assessment is genuinely present.

In the age of AI, the question is no longer whether the assignment is excellent. It is whether the assignment still tells us something true about the learner.